

didate. Rather than giving in, Uddhav bargained hard and, in return, bagged the Kalyan-Dombvli seat from BJP.

If all this proves anything, it is that the tiger (Shiv Sena symbol) is learning to purr. At a recent protest march against SEZs, which turned violent, the Sena softened its stand within 24 hours after Sainiks allegedly destroyed property and cars in Navi Mumbai. Attributing the violence to mobsters and angry protesters, the Sena was quick to distance itself from the violent events.

It's this pragmatism, which may ultimately work in favour of the party in the new era. It is doing things which a few years ago would have been unimaginable. Going by the alliances that Sena has been forging in the municipal councils and zilla parishads, it's evident that hardliner ideology is taking a backseat in the face of political compulsions. In Malegaon, a Muslim dominated area in western Maharashtra, the Sena came very close to tying up with the Indian Muslim Congress Party in the municipal council, as the city was smarting under apathetic Congress rule and saw little or no development. The alliance, however, did not materialise at the last minute. Justifying the party's decision, Uddhav says, "We don't hate Muslims, we are against anti-national people." The Sena's dalliances are not just restricted to Muslim parties. In municipal councils like Matheran, Yevla, Chiplun, Gangapur, Parbhani and Morshi the party has joined hands with the Congress, its arch rival in Maharashtra. Uddhav explains these strange alliances: "Whosoever wants to come together for the welfare of the state, is welcome."

Now the party is keen on a liaison with NCP, which is its coalition partner along with BJP in the Pune Municipal Corporation (PMC). However, the Sena is quietly doing its groundwork for the

elections and internal surveys show that the party can contest all 288 Assembly seats on its own.

Explaining the phenomenon of unlikely parties tying up to capture power, Venkatesh Kumar, associate professor at the Rajiv Gandhi Centre for Contemporary Studies, University of Mumbai, says: "In Maharashtra, we see marriages of convenience. The NCP-Sena alliance in PMC shows that

GOOD OLD DAYS: L.K. Advani shared good rapport with Balasaheb

they just wanted to capture power even at the expense of ideology."

Uddhav's desire to be a change agent is understandable as victory has been elusive, ever since he became the executive president in 2003. Despite the anti-incumbency wave in 2004, the Sena-BJP combine failed to seize power in Maharashtra. With elections to the state Assembly and Parliament less than two years away, parleys are already on between parties to work out

alliances and strategies. "We have been in alliance with BJP for the last 20 years but what have we achieved? We must look for what is lacking. We are two separate parties with different opinions and ideas," says Uddhav. BJP is also keeping its options open. Currently it's in talks with Raj's Maharashtra Navnirman Sena and other parties like the Peasants and Workers Party and the Republican Party of India (RPI). Uddhav's rivals also claim that at least 22 MLAs of Sena want to cross over to the Congress.

Matters are no different in the ruling Democratic Front where the Congress has played the big brother to NCP. Cracks are showing here too with NCP working on expanding its base for the 2009 polls and the Congress trying its best to merge NCP back into itself. "Our party will prefer to fight the 2009 elections alone. Even if there are political compulsions, we are ready to go with secular parties like the Janata Dal, Samajwadi Party, BSP, RPI and others," says Sachin Ahir, Mumbai president of NCP. The rift came to the fore after PMC elections this year when NCP joined hands with the Sena instead of the Congress.

Even as NCP and the Sena come to terms with the shortcomings of their respective allies, there is unlikely to be an open declaration of a partnership as NCP is also a key member of UPA at the Centre. But while the status quo remains, intense wooing continues. ■



HUSAIN FAWZAN

BEDFELLOWS ALL

WITH NCP: Pune Municipal Corporation, Amravati Zilla Parishad, Paithan and Vengurla Municipal Council.

WITH CONGRESS: Matheran, Yevla, Chiplun, Gangapur, Parbhani and Morshi Municipal Councils.

WITH PEASANTS AND WORKERS' PARTY: Uran Municipal Council

WITH REPUBLICAN PARTY OF INDIA: Jalgaon-Jamod Zilla Parishad

TIGER NUMBERS

LOK SABHA: 12

RAJYA SABHA: 4

MAHARASHTRA ASSEMBLY: 56